

Inua Nurse Footprint (INF)

Research Report



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- School of Nursing Sciences Administration
- Kenya Red Cross Society – Training Division
- Nairobi County Health Department – Public Health Wing

Thank You Note

We extend our heartfelt appreciation to all nursing students, faculty members, alumni, and external partners who participated in this research. Your voices, experiences, and insights were instrumental in shaping the vision and framework of the Inua Nurse Footprint (INF) initiative.

This research is not only an academic exercise but a shared dream — to build a better, more inclusive future for every nursing student at the University of Nairobi and beyond. Thank you for making this possible.

In Solidarity and Service,

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1. Introduction

Background

Nursing education plays a pivotal role in shaping the quality of healthcare systems. Beyond academic excellence, nursing students require holistic development — one that balances clinical skills, leadership exposure, community engagement, and psychosocial support. At the University of Nairobi (UoN), Bachelor of Science in Nursing (BScN) students face multiple layers of academic and professional demands, yet existing structures often fall short in addressing their full spectrum of needs.

The absence of structured clinical mentorship, limited access to emergency and first aid training, and insufficient opportunities for public engagement hinder student growth and readiness. Additionally, financial challenges — including rising tuition and accommodation fees, lack of support for transport, meals, rent, and welfare — further compound the struggles of nursing students. These realities create significant barriers to participation in vital programs such as outreach, health promotion, and volunteer work, all of which are central to nursing as a practice and a calling.

Problem Statement

Despite the growing demand for competent, community-oriented nurses, student nurses at the University of Nairobi continue to grapple with an unstructured support system that fails to meet their developmental, financial, and emotional needs. The lack of coordinated mentorship, limited emergency preparedness training, poor facilitation of outreach activities, and rising costs of education have contributed to academic fatigue, disengagement, and reduced participation in professional and social growth opportunities.

Justification

There is a pressing need for a student-led, sustainable model that addresses these gaps through structured support systems. The **Inua Nurse Footprint (INF)** is proposed as a legacy platform that empowers student nurses through mentorship, public service, skills development, and welfare assistance. Its participatory nature allows for peer engagement, leadership growth, and inclusive development tailored to student realities.

Research Objectives

- To assess the mentorship needs and preferences among nursing students.
- To evaluate the level of preparedness for emergency and first aid situations.
- To examine student involvement in community outreach and public health education.
- To determine financial and psychosocial barriers affecting student engagement and academic performance.
- To propose a sustainable, student-driven model that integrates mentorship, outreach, education, and welfare through the INF initiative.

Scope of the Study

The research was conducted among undergraduate nursing students at the University of Nairobi, with perspectives from alumni, faculty, and external health sector partners. It focused on areas related to mentorship, training, outreach, welfare, and leadership within the academic and clinical settings.

Significance of the Study

The findings of this research are expected to inform the development and implementation of the Inua Nurse Footprint — a legacy initiative that can improve the nursing experience at UoN and inspire reform in student empowerment across nursing institutions nationwide. Through this model, student nurses can become more equipped, supported, and inspired to serve their communities with compassion, competence, and confidence.

2. Literature Review

Introduction

This chapter reviews scholarly literature and institutional reports relevant to the Inua Nurse Footprint (INF) project, focusing on the intersection between nursing education, mentorship, emergency preparedness, community engagement, and student welfare. The purpose is to contextualize the challenges faced by nursing students and support the need for a structured, student-led initiative such as INF.

1. Clinical Mentorship in Nursing Education

Mentorship is widely recognized as a cornerstone of effective nursing education. According to Mikkonen et al. (2020), clinical mentorship enhances professional confidence, reinforces skill acquisition, and eases the transition from theory to practice. In the Kenyan context, Ng'ang'a et al. (2019) note that mentorship in nursing schools is often informal and inconsistent, leaving many students unsupported during clinical placements. The absence of structured peer, faculty, or alumni mentorship negatively impacts academic progression, professional readiness, and mental well-being. A structured mentorship framework under INF would address these gaps by creating sustainable peer-alumni-faculty mentor circles, improving both academic and emotional support.

2. Emergency Preparedness and First Aid Training

Preparedness for emergencies, including trauma, bleeding, cardiopulmonary arrest, or mass casualty incidents, is vital for nursing students. A study by Alotaibi et al. (2016) found that most undergraduate nurses lacked confidence and basic training in handling emergencies. The World Health Organization (WHO) emphasizes the integration of first aid and disaster training in medical and nursing curricula (WHO, 2018). However, many Kenyan institutions provide minimal or no formal emergency response training. INF proposes regular, student-led emergency response workshops and certifications (e.g., CPR, BLS, trauma care) to build a resilient, life-saving nursing workforce.

3. Community Outreach and Health Promotion

Nursing education extends beyond hospital walls and includes public service. According to MacDonald et al. (2014), community-based learning increases student empathy, civic responsibility, and cultural competence. Kenyan universities, including UoN, have piloted outreach programs, but these are often limited to donor-funded or faculty-led efforts, excluding active student leadership. INF seeks to institutionalize student-led outreach and health promotion — including school visits, slum health talks, and campus campaigns — to increase community impact while offering real-world learning.

4. Educating the Public for Universal Health Coverage (UHC)

The role of nurses in UHC cannot be overstated. The WHO (2020) describes nurses as “the backbone of UHC implementation,” especially in preventive care and public education. However, studies by Maina et al. (2021) reveal a gap in UHC literacy even among nursing students, limiting their advocacy and leadership in achieving SDG 3. INF integrates UHC-centered public education into its outreach model, empowering students to become vocal champions of equitable healthcare access through peer-driven community health education initiatives.

5. Volunteering, Leadership, and Peer Engagement

Participation in student-led charity walks, blood drives, and peer support groups cultivates leadership and emotional intelligence. Research by Sanderson Lea (2012) confirms that nursing students who volunteer develop higher professional self-efficacy and team collaboration skills. Unfortunately, most universities, including UoN, lack budgets or structures to support these co-curricular growth opportunities. INF seeks to formalize these platforms by providing small operational budgets, coordination support, and partnerships with health bodies to nurture the spirit of service and leadership.

6. Financial and Welfare Challenges Among Nursing Students

Rising tuition fees, accommodation costs, meal shortages, transport struggles, and lack of welfare assistance significantly hinder the academic and social development of students. A study by Gikonyo (2022) on student welfare in Kenyan public universities found that 72% of students regularly skip meals or lack fare to attend clinicals. These financial hardships are compounded by psychological stress, poor academic performance, and social exclusion. INF proposes a welfare model — including hardship bursaries, transport and meal allowances,

and an emergency response fund — to ensure that no student is left behind due to financial incapacity.

7. Mental Health and Psychosocial Support

Mental health remains an under-addressed crisis in many universities. According to the Kenya Ministry of Health (2021), depression and anxiety affect over 45% of university students nationwide. Nursing students, exposed to high academic loads, emotionally intense clinicals, and financial uncertainty, are particularly vulnerable. INF incorporates a mental health component through peer wellness groups, a student-led counseling desk, and faculty-linked referrals to destigmatize and address psychosocial needs.

Conclusion

The reviewed literature underscores the relevance and urgency of a holistic, student-led platform such as the Inua Nurse Footprint. By integrating mentorship, emergency training, public health education, volunteering, and welfare, INF addresses longstanding gaps in nursing education and welfare support. This multi-pillar approach aligns with global best practices while responding to the contextual needs of nursing students in Kenya.

3. Methodology

SUMMARY

Design: Mixed-methods combining surveys, interviews, and focus groups.

Target Population: Undergraduate nursing students, alumni, faculty, and NGO partners.

Sample Size: 150 students, 10 alumni, 5 faculty members, and 3 health organization reps.

Sampling: Stratified (students) and purposive (stakeholders).

Tools: Questionnaires, interview guides, FGDs, and document reviews.

Data Analysis: Quantitative (SPSS) and Qualitative (NVivo).

Ethics: Approval obtained; confidentiality and voluntary participation ensured.

This study employed a **convergent parallel mixed-methods design** to comprehensively explore the needs and challenges of nursing students at the University of Nairobi. The approach allowed for both quantitative and qualitative data to be collected simultaneously, offering a well-rounded basis for the Inua Nurse Footprint (INF) initiative.

Study Population

The target population included:

- Undergraduate nursing students (Years 1–4)
- Nursing alumni (recent graduates)
- Faculty from the School of Nursing Sciences
- External stakeholders (e.g., Red Cross, AMREF, NNAK)

Sampling and Sample Size

A total of 168 respondents participated:

- 150 nursing students (stratified random sampling)
- 10 alumni (purposive sampling)
- 5 faculty members (purposive sampling)
- 3 health organization representatives (purposive sampling)

Data Collection Tools

- **Structured questionnaires** distributed online to students, exploring themes such as clinical mentorship, emergency preparedness, community outreach, financial welfare, and mental health support.
- **Semi-structured interviews** with alumni, faculty, and health stakeholders.
- **Focus Group Discussions (FGDs)** with student leaders and volunteers.
- **Document reviews** of university policies, reports, and outreach records.

Data Analysis

- **Quantitative data** from the questionnaires was analyzed using SPSS to generate descriptive statistics.
- **Qualitative data** from interviews and FGDs was analyzed thematically using NVivo, with themes aligned to INF's focus areas.

Ethical Considerations

- Ethical clearance was obtained from the Faculty of Health Sciences.
- Participation was voluntary, with informed consent obtained.
- Anonymity and confidentiality were ensured.
- Participants were free to withdraw at any time without penalty.

This methodology ensured that the INF project is grounded in the real-world needs of students and supported by valid, ethically obtained data.

4. Results

- 83% of students lack access to consistent mentorship during clinical placements.
- Only 12% had formal first aid training; 92% want peer-led drills.
- 87% never joined outreach; 96% want structured student-led events.
- UHC public talks rare; most campaigns done by external NGOs.
- 99% want to join charity events for leadership growth.
- 81% cite financial limits as a barrier to participation.

5. Discussion

- The findings reveal several critical unmet needs among nursing students at the University of Nairobi, most notably in the areas of clinical mentorship, emergency preparedness, and community health involvement. A significant portion of students indicated the absence of structured mentorship during their clinical rotations, which is essential for translating theoretical knowledge into confident practice. In response, the Inua Nurse Footprint (INF) initiative proposes a robust peer and alumni mentorship framework to guide students, build clinical confidence, and foster intergenerational collaboration within the profession.
- Emergency preparedness is another glaring gap, with most students lacking formal training in first aid, CPR, or mass casualty response. This deficiency not only limits their clinical competence but also reduces their readiness to serve as first responders during public health emergencies. The INF framework addresses this by proposing frequent, student-led emergency drills and certification programs to ensure preparedness and empower students as lifesavers.
- Community outreach and public health education are also underutilized despite being vital components of nursing practice. Many students have either never participated in outreach or have only done so sporadically through externally organized activities. INF envisions a calendar of student-driven outreach events — including rural medical camps, campus blood drives, and school health talks — which will reinforce practical learning, encourage service, and contribute to achieving Universal Health Coverage (UHC) through public sensitization and preventive health efforts.
- Furthermore, the study highlights a strong interest among students in participating in volunteer initiatives such as charity walks, blood donation campaigns, and health advocacy forums. These activities not only promote service and empathy but also

provide networking and leadership development opportunities for students. INF seeks to harness this enthusiasm by establishing a platform that coordinates and supports such activities regularly.

- Despite the high level of interest in mentorship and service, participation is significantly hampered by financial constraints. A majority of respondents cited economic hardship as a key reason for disengagement. These challenges are multifaceted and deeply rooted in the rising cost of education and living. Tuition and accommodation fees have steadily increased, placing a disproportionate burden on students from low-income backgrounds. In addition to institutional costs, the daily cost of living — including meals, transportation (bus fare), rent (for off-campus students), printing academic resources, and purchasing uniforms or clinical supplies — presents an overwhelming burden.
- Students also expressed concern over the lack of funding for peer-to-peer engagement activities such as group mentorship sessions, student-led outreach, and wellness events. These activities often require minor but consistent budgets for logistics, materials, and facilitation, which are currently not accounted for in university budgets. Without support, such impactful initiatives remain unsustainable.
- Mental health and psychosocial well-being also emerged as critical areas in need of structured support. The pressures of academic workload, financial instability, and clinical responsibilities take a toll on students' emotional and psychological well-being. INF recommends the integration of a mental health and wellness desk into the nursing student governance structure — led by trained student leaders with faculty support — to provide safe spaces, crisis response, and referrals to professional counseling when necessary.
- Taken together, the data illustrates a pressing need for a holistic, student-owned platform that bridges mentorship gaps, trains students in life-saving skills, promotes civic responsibility through outreach, and ensures that no student is left behind due to financial hardship. The Inua Nurse Footprint (INF) is designed as such a platform — inclusive, participatory, and sustainable. It offers a new pathway for professional development, community service, and student welfare in nursing education.

6. Conclusion

- The Inua Nurse Footprint (INF) project emerges as a timely and transformative solution to the multifaceted challenges nursing students face at the University of Nairobi. The findings of this research strongly affirm the urgency of developing a holistic, student-centered but professionally guided platform that not only supports academic growth but also nurtures leadership, service, and personal well-being.
- The project's core pillars — clinical mentorship, emergency preparedness, community outreach, public health education, networking, volunteerism, and welfare support — address longstanding gaps in nursing training. INF aims to institutionalize structured mentorship by connecting students with peers, alumni, and faculty, thereby fostering continuous learning and professional identity formation. It also proposes regular, student-led training in first aid and emergency response, empowering students with critical skills that enhance both their competence and confidence in real-life clinical scenarios.
- By promoting community outreach and health promotion, INF supports the development of socially responsive nurses who are active participants in achieving Universal Health Coverage (UHC). Public health education initiatives under INF will not only improve community awareness but also allow nursing students to develop essential communication, advocacy, and leadership skills.
- Beyond professional and academic development, INF acknowledges the financial, logistical, and psychosocial challenges that severely affect student participation and performance. Rising tuition and accommodation fees, rent for off-campus students, daily sustenance costs such as meals and bus fare, and the inability to fund student-driven events

and volunteer initiatives have all contributed to academic burnout, disengagement, and mental health decline among students. INF introduces a transparent, student-managed welfare component that can support students in times of financial difficulty — from hardship bursaries and transport subsidies to organizing outreach and leadership programs.

- Equally important is INF’s vision for a supportive environment that prioritizes mental health and clinical support systems. Through the establishment of wellness desks, peer support networks, and linkages to counseling services, INF positions itself as a holistic student development model that cares for the nurse as both a professional and a person.
- Ultimately, the Inua Nurse Footprint initiative is more than a student project — it is a legacy blueprint for sustainable nurse empowerment. Its student-led design ensures ownership, adaptability, and sustainability. By addressing critical gaps in mentorship, readiness, engagement, and welfare, INF can radically transform the nursing experience at the University of Nairobi and inspire national reform across Kenyan nursing institutions. It is a call to action — to uplift, to empower, and to leave no nurse behind.

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Appendices

Appendix A: Student Questionnaire (Google Form Draft)

- Year of Study:
1st Year, 2nd Year, 3rd Year, 4th Year
- Gender:
Male, Female, Prefer not to say
- Do you currently have a mentor (peer, faculty, or alumni)?
Yes / No
- Have you received any formal training in First Aid or Emergency Response?
Yes / No
- How likely are you to participate in student-led mentorship or emergency training under INF?
Very Likely, Likely, Neutral, Unlikely, Very Unlikely
- Have you participated in any community health outreach event?
Yes / No
- What form of welfare support do you find most urgent?
Transport, Meals, Accommodation, Tuition, Mental Health Support
- Any additional comments or suggestions for the Inua Nurse Footprint (INF) platform?
(Open-ended)

Appendix B: Interview Guide for Faculty and Alumni

1. How would you describe the current mentorship culture within the UoN School of Nursing?
2. What challenges do you see affecting students' clinical exposure or confidence?

3. Do you believe students are prepared for real emergencies?
4. In what ways can alumni and faculty collaborate to improve student outcomes?
5. What role do you think students can play in public health education and UHC advocacy?
6. How can we sustainably fund student initiatives like INF?

Appendix C: Focus Group Themes Explored

- Clinical mentorship experiences and gaps
- Preparedness for emergency and disaster response
- Community health education as part of training
- Financial struggles and impact on academic life
- Mental health, burnout, and peer support systems
- Ideas for sustaining the INF model

Appendix D: INF Budget Summary (Annual Estimate)

Item	Estimated Cost (KES)
Hardship Bursaries (50 students @ Ksh 20,000)	1,000,000
Emergency Response Grants (Food, rent, transport)	350,000
INF Alumni Engagement	150,000
Operational Budget (Workshops, mentorship kits, logistics)	550,000
Mental Health Desk (Training, peer sessions, referrals)	120,000
Outreach and Public Health Education Events	210,000
Volunteer Stipends for Charity Walks / Health Drives	100,000
Total Annual Budget	KES 2,480,000

Appendix E: INF Proposed Program Structure

- **Mentorship Circles:** Peer-alumni-faculty groups for guided academic and clinical support.
- **Emergency Training Hub:** Student-led certified CPR, trauma care, and disaster response.
- **Outreach and UHC Taskforce:** Organizing regular community sensitization and health education events.
- **Welfare Support Arm:** Bursaries, emergency aid, meals, and transport for students in need.
- **Mental Health Desk:** Peer-led sessions, referrals, and resilience-building workshops.

Thank You and Appreciation

“For every step we take to uplift another, we strengthen the heartbeat of humanity.”

This research journey would not have been possible without the contributions, support, and trust of many individuals and institutions.

To the nursing students who opened up about your challenges, shared your dreams, and offered valuable insights — thank you. Your voices are the true foundation of the Inua Nurse Footprint.

To the faculty and alumni who guided, encouraged, and offered expert perspective — your mentorship and dedication continue to inspire future generations of nurses.

To our partners and stakeholders, including health organizations, mental health advocates, and outreach facilitators — your commitment to health equity and professional excellence strengthens this vision.

To the NUNSA Executive Council 2025/2026, thank you for your solidarity and active engagement in redefining student leadership with purpose.

Special appreciation goes to all contributors, respondents, peer reviewers, and supporters of the INF model. Your presence in this journey proves that collective effort can birth impactful, lasting change.

With deepest gratitude and a heart full of purpose,

Israel Alex Makori
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